The Conflict of ***Contrasts***

an INTERPRETIVE ANALYSIS with BARTOK

Alexander Goodhart

Introduction

Think of the "mouth feel", if you've partaken, of a Guinness Draught stout versus that of a hard seltzer. The nitrogen bubbles in Guinness are smaller than those in seltzer, and produce a denser foam and less effervescent liquid than the carbon-dioxide carbonation in the seltzer. It is nearly paradoxical: in our ignorant physiological self awareness, we may easily assume that a greater density of bubbles is going to lead to a more tongue-stimulating sensation. A forgivable misconception, and one that musicians must also learn.

When composing music that is highly complex in its rhythm, with the desired effect of textural complexity, one will likely discover that the ear often does not distinguish between musical voices in its reckoning of rhythmic texture, and that too many nested structures of rhythmic non-proportionality ultimately defeats its purpose: the spaces between impulses are filled in with other voices and, thus, a texture collapses from chaotic and percolated to smooth and fluid. If a performer is saddled with this conundrum, there must be some concerted effort to distinguish the voices, or else divert from the interpretive path the composer seems to have implied.

In spite of his generally mysterious artistic inclinations and the lack of program, Bartók does not leave much unimplied in his trio sonata, *Contrasts.* Here, in its first movement, I will examine the inherent conflict between the composer's intentions and the psychosensory experience of listening to the work, with the intention of edifying a theoretical and practical perspective on where the music's strengths lies and how we might shine light on them.

A Conflict

The conflict of performing the composition is a consolidation of the composer's intention and the means by which it is achieved. Bartók instructs the musicians to present ***contrast***. The material he provides for this task, however, is a piece composed of nitrogen bubbles. Especially when one considers the musical sensitivities of contemporary listeners (that is, a bit blunted to nuance within a specific classical genre, due to a much broader and often decontextualized palate of sounds we are regularly exposed to– and, lamentably, reduced engagement with classical music music making in general) it should be apparent that this music is extraordinarily dense with ideas.

Consider the outset of the music and the amount of information it condenses for an illustration of what the composer is doing for their *verbose* invocation of contrast.



In four measures, we have:

1. **Four instrumental textures** (vln. + piano, vln. solo, vln + clarinet, vln + clarinet + pno.)
2. **Two contrapuntal textures** (total counterpoint, melody + static accompaniment)
3. **Three modalities** (chromatic, whole tone, lydian)
4. **Two melodic motives** (opening tag and lydian melody)

This is the establishment of a pattern that continues throughout the movement. It is true that all music, with certain deconstruction, can be shown to be veritably kaleidoscopic in the interdependencies of their disparate forces. Tempi indications help to illustrate, further, the composer's commitment to contrast; an excerpt from the movement of just thirty-two measures gives…

1. Più tranquillo 2. Meno mosso 3. Più mosso 4. Meno mosso 5. Più mosso 6. Tempo I 7. Tranquillo

…seven indications.

For the performers, however, this is a great convenience. The composer's explicit demarcations help provide a roadmap to the piece's structure. That structure is precisely what must be elucidated as convincingly as possible in order to preserve the "inner conflict" without conflicting with the audience's sensibilities.

The reason that contrast can overwhelm the audience is not because they simply cannot handle too great of a variety of ideas. As a pure music without words, the ideas presented to them are inherently

ambiguous. The audience will be working, from measure one, to connect these ideas. They want a coherent narrative, a frame of reference, and an experience at least partly rooted in emotion. We cannot feel emotion for events that have no specific meaning, we cannot construct meaning without relating disparate concepts, and we cannot form a narrative without the ability to discern how the concepts interrelate and are affected by each other. This is sometimes lost in the language that segments of society use to discuss art and entertainment: we may say our favorite *character* in a book, the *shocking twist* at the movie's ending, the *incredible leap* in the ballet's climax. But none of those ideas are powerful, of course, without the connections in time and space and spirit.

In *Contrasts*, then, musicians must strike the delicate balance between the density of Bartók's ideas and the clarity of their presentation, both illuminating the contrasts for their visibility and keeping the interrelatedness of them at the fore.

A Story

Ultimately, whether we conjure specific images or ideas or not, a sense of *narrative* is key to maintaining an audience's engagement. It is also an asset in the learning and interpretation of material for performance. Narrative provides the audience with key pieces of information that contribute a significant, if not *majority*, portion of what facilitates the enjoyment of / engagement with / participation in music.

Music is one among several art forms that rely on time's passing to present itself. Temporality is a factor in all art, as nothing can be wholly observed/understood/absorbed in one instant. Doubtless, though, that some media are more reliant on time. Often without the concrete ideas of storytelling, musical narratives

are in a delicate position where their proportions and gestures must be very effectively crafted to maintain a through-line of meaning and guide one's attention; this is an added variable set that allows music to be so variously embodied and so intricately complex. Often intuited, and aided by archetypes, this guidance helps a listener contextualize everything they hear— which allows even the strangest sounds and combinations to be accepted.

With a well-communicated sense of narrative, an audience member has an impression of *where* they are in a work's unfolding. Imagine being 6 minutes into a Beethoven symphony and believing it was about to finish. Or else, imagine if the opening trumpet figure in *Also Sprach Zarathustra* were orchestrated for the whole brass section marked *fortissimo*. Eventually, in the former, you would grow tired of waiting for this ending to arrive. In the latter, the glorious arrival of the Sun and humanity's great awakening would not be noticeable, as the audience was already just blinded by a wall of sound, and so the anticipation of change would have not been met.

Thus, in order to communicate *any* music effectively, the various intertwined concepts of drama and storytelling are necessary decisions and intuitions that must be considered in the ultimate formation of a narrative.

A Realization

In execution of music, performers must have a story to tell. It could be their story, the composer's, a middle ground or imagined one. It could be consciously constructed or innate and even improvisatory.

What "story" is Bartók telling in the first movement of *Contrasts*? A fitting exploration of this question parallels the manner in which it must be discovered, for the composition is a trio, and only in combination with other players– other perspectives– can the meaning of the music emerge. Perhaps, then, one of the ways that *Contrasts'* makes good on its titular promise is the music's reliance on musicians'"collaborating in opposition". While it may be unwise for a pianist to *tell* a clarinetist or violinist how to perform their part, it does more than a little help to take a look through each individually and comparatively, and construct an interpretation that plays with *and against* the other parts.

Doing so reveals a bit about the roles being played by the instrumentalists. It can be noted that the clarinet is given thematic material the most often throughout the first movement: only during the brief middle section's lilting folk dance does the clarinet *not* have thematic material while another instrument does. The piano, on the other hand, is never given sole foreground treatment and, indeed, the lydian use of the piece's main theme is never played on the piano. In this sense, the piece is functioning as more of a *concerto grosso* than a trio sonata. As such, the narrative of the music can be thought to, primarily, be born out of the dialogue between its "soloists," the clarinet and violin.

In a concerto grosso, the soloists are distinguished by their thematic prominence and interplay, while the accompanying forces provide a textural and rhythmic foundation that frames their dialogue. In *Contrasts*, Bartók adapts this dynamic: showing us a dialogue marked by tension. The clarinet, with its fluidity and wide range, frequently assumes the role of a melodic protagonist, spinning intricate, folk-inspired lines that demand an expressive and flexible interpretation. By contrast, the violin alternates between complementing the clarinet's material and challenging it with sharp rhythmic disruptions, sudden shifts in articulation, and modal contrasts that require precision and agility. There is an interesting contradiction in the manner in which the violin accompanies the clarinet in the first measures versus the first section marked Più tranquillo. Oddly enough, this latter part is significantly *less* tranquil than whence it arrives, and the violin has gone from gentle supporter to somewhat exasperated: reeling even, in exaggerated and tonally discordant arpeggiations. Perhaps this is a

response to what preceded– after all, the violin was dutifully submissive to the confident jaunt the clarinet takes in the beginning. Were they thanked– given their own opportunity to bask in the light? No: the greedy clarinet moved right from its saccharine melody to ostentatious folk mode scaling and trills before having the gall to go off and gallivant *a due* with piano!

Such an anthropomorphization may be outside the realm of some musicians' comfort zones. I'd posit, though– why? As performers, we are acting– always. It is a fiction that "Argerich plays the music, Lang Lang displays the music." Rather than dogmatic faith in the truth of our presentations, we should embrace the real fiction: that the music is always subjectively interpretable.
Is the concept of adversaries and jealousy/contempt a stranger to the composition?

Note how, after the violin returns with its harsher and throatier rendition of the lydian theme, we reach the lilting dance of the Meno mosso. We see, at first, the competition between the voices; the clarinet takes up whatever space is left unmoving by the clarinet until jettisoning towards its stratosphere and interrupting the dance– the piano is tracking the the rising drama. When thematic clarity returns with a restatement of the dance theme, it is the first moment of rhythmic unison between the soloists, and is marked *forte*. If the performers are imagining that they have been "vying for attention," then, at this moment, they are acknowledging each other and thus each other's subversion. So, then, this unison can adopt an affect of the players in "locked horns," their internal contempt spilling out and leading to confrontation.

There are so many ways this situation could be rendered on the stage. The manner and intensity of dynamic adjustments and articulations, the physical posture and movement of the players. How much work would it take to settle upon this interpretation if not for the succinct fiction of jealousy amongst the parts. Moreover, this kind of dramatic grounding communicates a dimension of the music with such clarity; the audience will not have

noticed how many tempo, textural, thematic, modal and etc. transformations and permutations have occurred. Those are the many gestures and affects that resonate from every action– what matters is *the action itself.*

Conclusion

Verbunkos' challenging and animated spirit exemplifies how Bartók's ***Contrasts*** invites performers and listeners alike to navigate its dense and unfamiliar ideas. This challenge demands an interpretive approach that transcends technical execution and theoretical analysis, embracing the dramatic interplay inherent in the work.
Despite its intricate layering, ***Contrasts*** is far from a mere collection of fragmented concepts. To unify its elements effectively, performers must adopt a framework that not only guides them from the opening measure to the conclusion, but also animates the music's expressive potential. I propose that drama (animosity, in this movement's case) as an interpretive lens will offers a limitless and fluid path to achieving this cohesion. By understanding the music as a dialogue, performers unlock its narrative potential—a potential that, while unspoken, resonates deeply with audiences.

The true beauty and success of Contrasts lie in its paradoxical nature: its density creates space, its ambiguity invites meaning. Through this, the music becomes not just an intellectual exercise, but a deeply resonant journey tailored to the musician and their audience. Ultimately, this unified approach does justice to a great work, a "conflict of contrasts", as a rich and rewarding statement of technique and artistry.